5 Must-Haves in a Virtual Leasing Office



ResMan®

Go Virtual. Stay Competitive.

Transform your leasing office to be 100 percent virtual, serve your back office with time-saving features and boost your leasing efforts during challenging times.



> **What makes the biggest difference in business? Employee engagement, attention to detail, customer service, the environment of your properties, and consistency.**
>
> **-Elizabeth Francisco**
> **ResMan Founder & CEO**

We're all facing significant disruptions in our personal and professional life today due to COVID-19 – but that's nothing compared to the change we can expect in the next two years in the property management industry. Leveraging a quality lease management software with a virtual leasing office is no longer a luxury. It's a necessity for survival.

If you're wondering how to transform your leasing office to be 100 percent virtual, these are the top things to consider to make sure you choose one that serves your back office with time-saving features and boosts your leasing efforts:

- High-Converting Website
- Virtual Tours
- Flexible Communication Tools
- Customizable Resident Portal
- The Personal Touch

A solution that fits the entire resident lifecycle.

HIGH-CONVERTING WEBSITE

4 Website Necessities for Converting Prospects to Residents

Your #1 focus should be on having a top-converting website to increase your pipeline, drive brand awareness, and communicate with residents. Yes, a great site can do all of this, and you shouldn't settle for less.

ResMan®

What is a *high-converting website?*

Websites that convert simply means they work; they turn prospects into residents. They do this with appealing, well-formatted and optimized content that streamlines a path from a prospect's first visit to the next step and the next, until finally they become residents. It takes the guesswork out of the process for visitors. It provides the information they need and guides them along intuitively.

To be high converting, your website will need to be:

1. Easily Found

For your website to show up in someone's search results, your site will have to be optimized with the terms people are using in their searches, called keywords. There are many tools that can help you discover the best ones for your property, but it can be complicated.

The competion for keyword ranking is fierce because 93% of searchers only look at the first page results (Source). That's why most organizations today hire a marketer with Search Engine Optimzation (SEO) experience or contract with an agency to manage this for them...it's that important.

Do some mystery shopping on your own online real estate...have someone search for it on an outside computer without using the property name (for example, best apartments in Charlotte or Deep Ellum, Dallas).



Where do you land on their search results? If you're not on page 1 for your keywords, it's time to enlist some experienced SEO assistance.

2. Appealing, Current & Informative

Once a visitor lands on your site, what do they see? Your apartment website design should be attractive, clean and simple. But how it looks isn't all that matters. When they click through, do they find up to date listings? Do your images showcase your property as an experience prospects immediately imagine themselves in?

Can they take a virtual tour? Can they see themselves living in and loving your place? If your listings offer the barest of details without providing some color, they probably can't.

Gather feedback from your mystery shopper and get your most creative copywriter to punch up the content on your site with every feature detail you can imagine, individualized to showcase a sunrise view or the quiet atmosphere and shaded parking of particular units.

Take a page from the playbook of successful brands: Showcase smiling people enjoying staged apartments and sparkling amenities.

3. Easy to Navigate & Mobile-Friendly

Do you know the impression your website is leaving with prospects? Even if it's beautiful, it can still be structured poorly. Visitors should be able to locate at a glance the specific information they're seeking, even if they're browsing on their phone.

Make sure that your apartment website hosting includes mobile responsiveness. This is important because 70% of web traffic happens on a mobile device (Source) and 57% of users say they won't recommend a business with a poorly designed mobile site. (Source).

And your site is unlikely to show up in top Google ratings if it isn't mobile-friendly.

ResMan®

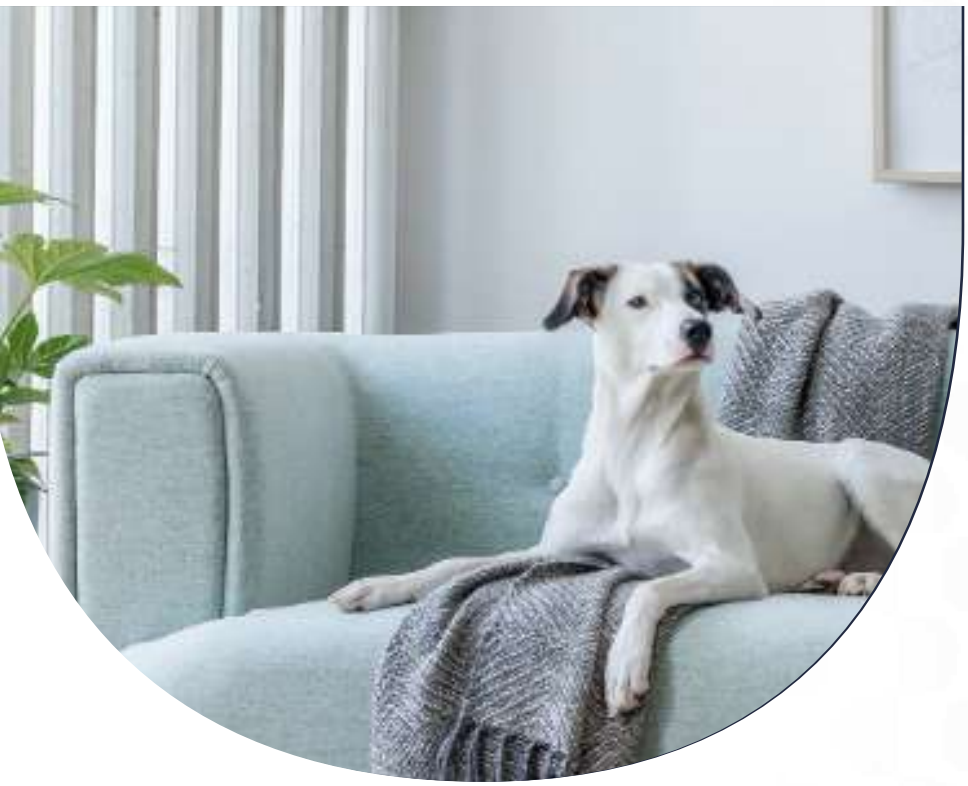
2901 Dallas Parkway, STE 200, Plano, Texas 75093

www.myresman.com

1(888)702-0971



Can prospects imagine themselves in your spaces?



4. Equipped with Convenient Online Leasing Tools

If a prospect finds on your website a place they want to call home, it should be just an obvious click from there to locate and complete an online application, screening, leasing agreement and make a payment. It should include an intuitive resident portal that allows residents to manage everything online, even from a mobile device.

Glitchy tools that don't work on their phones or a partially virtual process that still requires a few manual steps just won't cut it.

Remember, visitors equate your website with your properties. They're looking for convenience. As they interact with your website and virtual leasing office, many believe that however enjoyable or frustrating the process is, it's a sign of what future dealings will be like with your staff and portal for maintenance requests, monthly payments and more, if they decide to lease from you.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

- **An agnostic property management system to easily integrate your application process**
- **Templates and automation capabilities**
- **A "What you see is what you get" visual editor**
- **3D floor plans and interactive site maps.**

ResMan®

2901 Dallas Parkway, STE 200, Plano, Texas 75093

www.myresman.com

1(888)702-0971

VIRTUAL TOURS

4 Ways Virtual Tours Help You Generate More Leads

We've all heard that a picture is worth a thousand words. And it's true. Photography on your website allows prospective residents to quickly assess the potential of various properties and reduce walk-throughs before deciding on their new home.

But even if they like what they see on your website, they know it's impossible to completely grasp the scale, surroundings and true condition of a space simply from still shots.

In light of COVID-19 restrictions, consumers' fast-paced lives, and the culture's love of tech convenience, virtual tours are worth a million words, providing the convenience and time-savings modern residents demand. And they help property managers, too.

1. You can showcase your properties 24/7

Hosting tours while you sleep was once a revolutionary way to stay ahead of your competition, but no more. It's no longer a luxury, it's a necessity if you want to stay competitive. If prospects have to wait til tomorrow or the weekend to view your properties, but they can explore another property via a 3D virtual tour while they watch TV at the end of the day, your competitor has the jump on you.

And aside from the perpetual access it gives them, people just prefer video to still photos. Data shows that apartment listings with virtual tours receive 87% more views than those without virtual tours. (Source)

2. Better-qualified leads save your staff time

Showing apartments, especially multiple layouts, is time-consuming. And many tours end with lost leads. Allowing prospects to get a better idea about whether a space is right for them before you show it means more serious candidates who schedule walk-throughs.

Research shows that 75 percent of renters prefer interactive virtual tours over ordinary photographs and that these tours influenced their purchase decision. (Source: Estate Agent)

3. You can reach extended audiences

Virtual tours may be a deciding factor for certain groups of people, including,

- Out of town prospects who can't schedule a walk-through but need to move in quickly.
- Individuals with disabilities and/or restricted mobility who want to reduce the number of properties they visit in person.

And, during COVID-19 restrictions, virtual tours allow your staff to remain safely distanced while tours for all demographics continue.

4. Virtual tours send a message of convenience that can improve lease rates

Researchers at Nielsen state that "in today's hyperconnected world, convenience is the ultimate currency." (Source)

Modern technology and convenient online tools that create a smooth leasing process send a positive message about life after the signing the lease. They reflect well on your brand.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

- **Property sitemaps** that allow you to showcase unit availability and display visual details about a unit's location, floor amenities, balcony views, and much more on an interactive sitemap.
- **Interactive building and floor selector,** which lead your website visitors through a virtual floor selection experience to view availability and navigate between multiple buildings and floor levels.
- **Virtual tours and video integrations** that let you to create a visually stunning digital experiences with any 2D or 3D Floor Plan through Matterport, Razz, and other top platforms.

ResMan®

2901 Dallas Parkway, STE 200, Plano, Texas 75093

www.myresman.com

1(888)702-0971



FLEXIBLE COMMUNICATION TOOLS

The Evolution and Future of Property Management Communications

Flexible communication tools are a vital ingredient of a virtual leasing office. There was a time when email was king of property management communication tools. It's still important and a key component of flexible communication. However, even before COVID, this trend had shifted. People no longer want to interact with people to conduct their business via phone, and fewer people are responding to email.

Consumers want to do as much as possible on their phones, through text messages and chat apps: 58% of consumers have tried to reply with a text message after missing a call from a business. And consumers are 4 times more likely to respond to a text message than call back to a voicemail. (Source)

This customer-driven shift is not over, and "it's time to embrace the benefits of it," says ResMan's founder and President Elizabeth Francisco:

"Our industry is behind. We use terms like customer conversion and customer retention when we should be hyper-focused on the customer experience. That experience is driven by expectations, which are driven by emerging technology used by brands like Amazon and Netflix."

EMAIL

As we've stated, email is still important, especially for global blasts to your entire resident population. But it has grown up. Without modern, flexible tools, email can be time-consuming and inefficient for staff. A super simple platform that allows your staff to automate and customize templated messaging is the answer.

Imagine being able to standardize your messaging across all your properties and ensure that every communication sent reflects the professionalism, tone, and experience you want for your residents. This is where email shines.

INTEGRATED SMS/TEXT

Business text messaging is emerging as a leading tool for providing contextual and conversational experiences, with 85% of consumers wanting to be able to send texts to and receive texts from businesses. (Source) It's the fastest, most convenient, and singularly preferred channel for communicating with organizations.

Open rates tell the story. While email open rates have dropped to ~25%, SMS open rates are at an astounding 90+%, allowing property managers to communicate with residents and prospects more efficiently. It's even more efficient if your texting capability is integrated into your property management software.

If you haven't moved to integrated SMS/text messaging, you're already behind the curve. Texting is powerful for your client, but when SMS is integrated into your property management software, your staff can

ResMan®



become communication rockstars providing stellar customer experiences.

Integrated SMS allows staff to view an ongoing text thread with any resident from any screen in your software that contains their information. You simply click to continue the dialogue. In seconds, any staff member can be up to date on all text conversations with that individual, no matter which leasing agent has been a part of the conversation.

This is important for both conversions and retention. If a prospect looking at multiple properties can only be reached via email or phone call with answers for their questions or to set up an appointment, any property manager with text messaging can beat you to the punch. This is true not only in terms of speed, but also of providing the customer experience potential residents are looking for. For current residents who are late on their rent or need maintenance help, a quick text message shortens communication time and is more likely to get a response.

CHATBOTS

The next step in the evolution of flexible communication tools for property managers is AI.

Artificial intelligence is not the future for your customers; it's already here. They already browse sites where completely automated cyber robots start a conversation with them, then hand them over to a human for a live chat, if needed.

Remember, fewer consumers than ever want to deal face-to-face or by phone with a person, especially for their initial evaluation of offerings. And while the property management industry has lagged in the adoption of emerging communication technology, chatbots are on their way.

To stay competitive, property managers must have a mindset that prioritizes innovation for creating a positive customer experience.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

- **Integrated SMS/Text messaging** to communicate with staff and residents via unlimited messages and tracked conversations from within platform.
- **Customizable, automated email tools,** with built-in templates and merge fields**.**
- **Chatbots:** In use or in development.
- **Internal communication tools** that allow staff to assign tasks in workflow and annotate customer profiles with notes to keep everyone on the same page.

ResMan®

2901 Dallas Parkway, STE 200, Plano, Texas 75093
www.myresman.com
1(888)702-0971

CUSTOMIZABLE USER PORTAL



The Power of the Portal: Creating a Community Hub with Your Resident Portal

Your prospects and residents crave convenience and a resident portal is an online platform designed specifically to make your residents' lives easier.

How important is it? In a 2018 study of 2,000 renters, 80% considered it a must-have (Source). An online resident portal allows residents, at the very least, to conveniently pay their rent online, submit maintenance requests, and receive notices from your staff. In light of today's consumer-driven demand for convenience through technology—especially since the onset of COVID-19—these are important features to provide.

But what if your resident portal could be...and do...more?

Most leasing software for apartments provides a resident portal of some kind, which residents use for the tasks mentioned above to a varying degree. The more residents who use the portal to manage their communications and payments, the easier property management is for your staff.

What if your resident portal could become a forum for renters to connect and collaborate with each other, helping your residents form a real community?

During the pandemic, some property managers have taken advantage of the incredible opportunity to provide social value to residents via their portals. They've united their community in fun activities, helping to foster the satisfaction that can lead to renewals.

With social distancing still in place, live events may be out for now but there are other ways to connect your residents using your portal and/or social media:

- **Contests.** Engage tenants through fun contests that can range from food-drive competitions to costume contests to even who can get the most likes on a pet picture. (Source)
- **Skills Board.** Looking for someone who can knit? Seeking a commuting ride-share? Connect residents through shared needs and resources.
- **News & Notes.** Share information about local activities, tips for growing plants on a balcony or hanging pictures without damaging a wall, calendar events and announcements, and resources for those who may need assistance during the economic downturn (i.e. Organizations such as Apartment Life, a nonprofit that connects residents with local charities and social services.)
- **Portal Engagement Campaign.** The more people who engage through your portal, the more effectively you can manage your properties. So it could be worthwhile to offer incentives.
  - Reward new users who login during your portal drive period and take any kind of action (or a specific action) with valuable offers on local amenities or a discount specific to your property.
  - Reward current users with Resident of the Month recognition and a gift card through a random drawing of those who pay their rent online.

ResMan®

2901 Dallas Parkway, STE 200, Plano, Texas 75093

www.myresman.com

1(888)702-0971

Not all resident portals are created equal.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

- **Work Order Requests.** Residents can submit their requests and even upload images to demonstrate the issue, then track and provide feedback on the work order within the portal throughout the entire process.
- **Online Payments.** Integration with an open API and unrestricted payment provider allows residents to not only securely pay rent, but also view payment history, balances, and receipts.
- **Documents storage.** Property managers can store documents within the online resident portal for easy access by residents anytime, anywhere.
- **Customizable calendar.** Add new or recurring events and planned maintenance to keep residents informed.
- **Package Notifications.** Notify residents of package delivery along with tracking numbers, sender, and all pickup history.
- **Residents Permissions.** Enable residents to choose from permission levels to enter their unit, from one time pick-ups to unlimited access.



THE PERSONAL TOUCH

Technology Can't Replace Relationships

Remember that the two main purposes for implementing modern technology into your property management (convenience for residents and staff) really boil down to one reason:

By making your staff's job easier, they save time and frustration, freeing them up to provide the personal touch that only real humans can provide.

No software is going to provide a personal touch without real humans being visible to your tenants. Each aspect of a GREAT property management platform we've covered here frees up staff to be available and visible, but it makes them look good. It makes you look good.

Unfortunately, leasing staff and property managers sometimes fail to use all the tools in their property management software toolbox.

Better platform utilization ensures that the team can more effectively convey the personal touch, so make sure they get the training they need to learn all that your lease management software can do. Set the expectation that everyone will need to lean on it.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

With a comprehensive property management platform like ResMan, leasing staff and property managers have the ability to provide the resident lifestyle that contemporary renters expect.

ResMan®

2901 Dallas Parkway, STE 200, Plano, Texas 75093

www.myresman.com

1(888)702-0971